

Air pollution norms went up in smoke

Bringing a decade-old tussle to a close, MoEF last week **scrapped** its 2015 **norms** for SO₂ **emissions** from coal-fired power plants (CFPPs), the chief source of these emissions. The **rollback** is **significant** **given** the country's **reliance** on coal, and it plans to add 80 GW of capacity by 2031-32. The country has been the world's top SO₂ emitter since 2017. **Following** this decision, NTPC asked BHEL to **halt** flue gas desulphurisation (FGD) installations at five under-construction CFPPs after GoI **exempted** most thermal plants from FGD requirements. As of February, **537 thermal units** totalling 204 GW capacity **were** identified for installation of FGDs.

The rollback raises key questions on the role of science in policymaking, the priority given to environmental and human **wellbeing** and gaps in regulation. MoEF **claims** its decision is 'based in science', suggesting the 2015 norms were not. The new rules classify SO₂ as a pollutant based on **geography**, not plant size or emissions. About 11% of plants—those within 10 km of Delhi-NCR or million-plus cities—must install FGDs by December 2027. Another 11% may or may not, depending on an expert review committee. **Ambient** air quality now **takes precedence** over pollution-at-source, which National Clean Air Programme (NCAP) had **emphasised**.



None of the studies **cited** for the new rules were **commissioned** by the environment ministry. Weak **implementation** of continuous emissions **monitoring** **made** it difficult to challenge the rollback with source-level data. The real roadblock was who would **foot** the desulphurisation **bill**. Studies **peg** the cost at ₹0.5-1 crore/MW, adding ₹0.25-0.75/kWh to tariffs. Instead of **addressing** whether this cost would be **passed on** to consumers or **subsidised**, GoI returned to the old **binary** of cost versus environmental and human health.

[Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

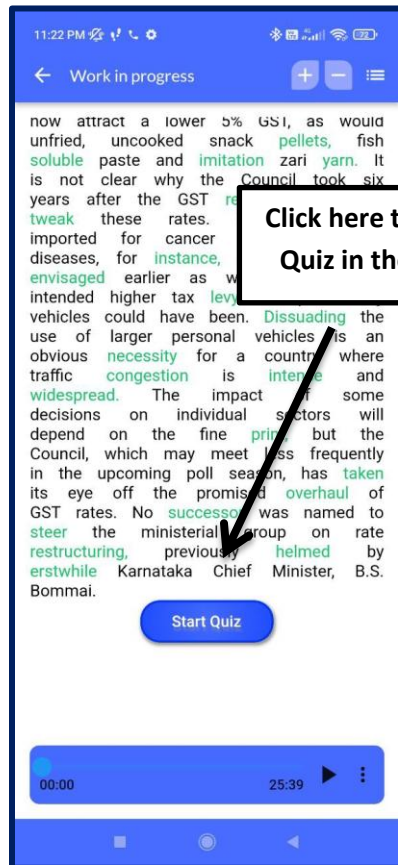
1. **Go up in smoke** (phrase) – Disappear, vanish, be ruined, collapse, be destroyed
ध्वस्त हो जाना / नष्ट हो जाना
2. **Bring to a close** (phrase) – End, conclude, terminate, finish, wrap up समाप्त करना
3. **Decade** (noun) – Period of Ten years, दशक
4. **Scrap** (verb) – Cancel, discard, abolish, revoke, eliminate रद्द करना
5. **Norm** (noun) – Standard, rule, guideline, benchmark, regulation मानक
6. **Emission** (noun) – Discharge, release, outflow, ejection, exhalation उत्सर्जन
7. **Rollback** (noun) – Reversal, withdrawal, rescinding, cancellation, retreat वापसी / वापसी का फैसला
8. **Significant** (adjective) – Important, notable, substantial, meaningful, considerable महत्वपूर्ण
9. **Given** (preposition) – Considering, taking into account, in view of, due to, because of ध्यान में रखते हुए
10. **Reliance** (on) (noun) – Dependence, trust, confidence, faith, assurance निर्भरता
11. **Following** (preposition) – After, subsequent to, in the wake of, post, as a result of के बाद
12. **Halt** (verb) – Stop, cease, pause, discontinue, terminate रोकना
13. **Exempt** (verb) – Excuse, exclude, relieve, spare, discharge छूट देना
14. **Wellbeing** (noun) – Health, welfare, comfort, safety, prosperity कल्याण
15. **Claim** (verb) – Assert, declare, maintain, state, allege दावा करना
16. **Geography** (noun) – Region, terrain, topography, area, land भौगोलिक क्षेत्र / भूगोल
17. **Ambient** (adjective) – Surrounding, encompassing, encircling, atmospheric, environmental चारों ओर का / परिवेशी
18. **Take precedence** (over) (phrase) – Prevail over, dominate, outweigh, override, be more important प्राथमिकता होना
19. **Emphasise** (verb) – Highlight, stress, underline, accentuate, point out ज़ोर देना
20. **Cite** (verb) – Mention, refer to, quote, allude to, invoke उल्लेख करना

21. **Commission** (verb) – Authorize, assign, order, appoint, contract आदेश देना / नियुक्त करना
22. **Monitoring** (noun) – Observation, surveillance, tracking, inspection, supervision निगरानी
23. **Foot the bill** (phrase) – Pay, bear the cost, cover expenses, finance, shoulder खर्च उठाना
24. **Peg** (verb) – Fix, set, determine, estimate, assign निर्धारित करना
25. **Address** (verb) – Tackle, deal with, confront, handle, resolve समाधान करना / ध्यान देना
26. **Pass on** (verb) – Transfer, shift, hand over, delegate, relay स्थानांतरित करना
27. **Subsidise** (verb) – Support, finance, sponsor, underwrite, fund सब्सिडी देना
28. **Binary** (noun) – Duality, dichotomy, contrast, twofold division, polarity द्वैधता / दो में बंटा हुआ विचार

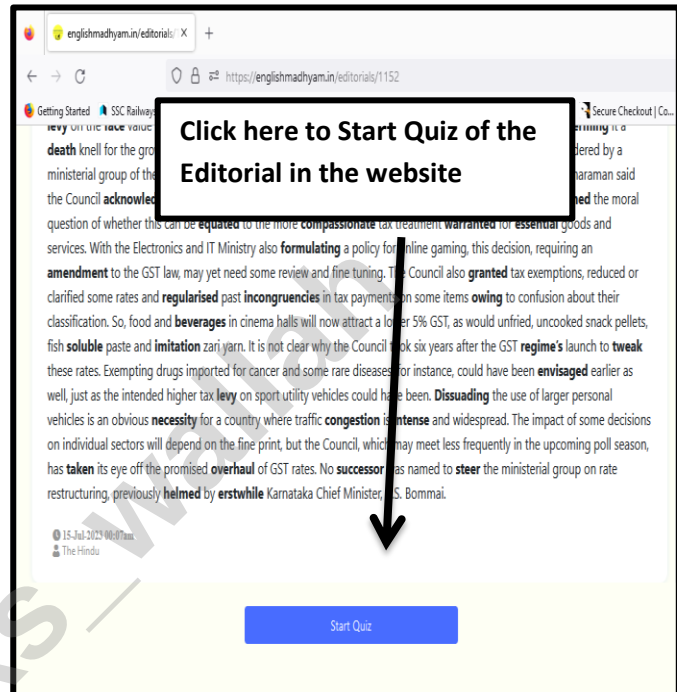
Summary of the editorial

1. MoEF Scraps 2015 Norms – The Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEF) scrapped the 2015 sulphur dioxide (SO₂) emission norms for coal-fired power plants (CFPPs).
2. India's SO₂ Emission Status – India has been the world's top SO₂ emitter since 2017, primarily due to coal dependence.
3. Major Policy Reversal – The rollback marks the end of a decade-long debate on enforcing stricter environmental norms for CFPPs.
4. NTPC Halts FGD Installations – After the rollback, NTPC directed BHEL to stop installing flue gas desulphurisation (FGD) units at five new plants.
5. FGD Implementation Plan Stalled – As of February, 537 thermal units (204 GW) were identified for FGD installation, but most will now be exempt.
6. Coal Expansion Continues – Despite pollution concerns, India plans to add 80 GW of new coal power capacity by 2031–32.
7. Scientific Basis Questioned – The government claims the new norms are “based in science,” implying the older norms lacked scientific foundation.
8. SO₂ Classification by Geography – The new rules classify SO₂ emissions based on plant location, not the plant's size or pollution output.
9. Only Select Plants Covered – Just 11% of plants near Delhi-NCR and major cities must comply with FGD norms by December 2027.
10. Expert Review for Others – Another 11% of plants are under conditional review by an expert committee, while the rest face no FGD requirement.
11. Ambient vs Source-Level Focus – The focus has shifted from controlling emissions at the source to maintaining ambient air quality, diluting NCAP's goals.
12. Lack of MoEF-Commissioned Studies – The studies justifying the rollback were not commissioned by the MoEF, raising transparency concerns.
13. Weak Monitoring Systems – Poor implementation of continuous emissions monitoring weakened evidence-based opposition to the policy reversal.
14. Economic Cost of FGDs – Installing FGDs costs ₹0.5–1 crore/MW, potentially raising electricity tariffs by ₹0.25–0.75/kWh.
15. Cost vs Health Trade-off – Instead of addressing who should bear the cost, the government defaulted to the old cost vs health debate, sidelining environmental and public health priorities.

Practice Exercise: Banking Pattern Based



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